

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Tyndale Open Study Notes

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Passing On Authority and Responsibility to a New Leader

The role of a Christian leader is to serve and endure difficulties for those they guide ([Mark 10:35-45](#)). For the apostle Paul, good leadership meant setting an example like Jesus Christ. Jesus's death on the cross was the most important thing to Paul, and it completely shaped how he lived his life. He said, "I want to know ... the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to Him in His death" ([Philippians 3:10](#); see [Colossians 1:24](#)).

He meant more than emotional struggles or dealing with sin. He meant experiencing violent physical suffering. Paul endured difficulties for those with whom he shared the good news. He always made their salvation a priority over his own safety ([2 Timothy 2:10](#); [2 Corinthians 4:8-12](#)).

A Christian leader's life shows others about Jesus' death on the cross. It shows how God works powerfully even through weak human beings ([2 Corinthians 12:8-10](#)). It also shows God's wisdom despite human foolishness ([1 Corinthians 1:18-31](#)). When Paul called the apostle Timothy to lead, he also called him to "endure hardship" ([2 Timothy 4:1-5](#); [1:8](#); [2:3](#); [4:5](#)). Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the cross ([1:8](#)).

True Christian leadership must follow Jesus Christ's example of putting others first. When leaders focus on themselves instead of Christ, they fail to live out the good news of Jesus. A good leader follows Jesus's example by serving and caring for others, not seeking their own benefit (see [Philippians 2:3-8](#)). These leaders are ready to experience difficult times. They know that those who share in Jesus' death will also share in his life, and those who remain faithful through difficulties will share in his rule ([2 Timothy 2:11-12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[John 13:15](#); [Acts 20:35](#); [2 Corinthians 4:8-12](#); [Ephesians 5:2](#); [Colossians 1:24](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:6-7](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:9](#); [1 Timothy 1:16](#); [4:12](#); [2](#)

[Timothy 1:8](#), [12](#); [2:3](#), [10-12](#); [4:1-5](#); [Titus 2:7](#); [Hebrews 6:12](#); [13:7](#); [1 Peter 2:21](#); [5:1-4](#)

Paul's Role as an Apostle

To understand Paul's role as an apostle of Jesus Christ, a good place to read is the description in the second letter to the Corinthians. In this letter, Paul shares the core of his ministry. Paul was God's special messenger to establish and care for churches in the non-Jewish (gentiles) world. He served with seriousness and sincerity. His message dealt with life and death issues ([2 Corinthians 2:15-17](#)). As an early Christian missionary, he brought the good news about Jesus (the gospel) to places where people had not heard about Jesus (see [Romans 15:20-21](#)).

Paul's message of good news was plain and direct (see, for example, [2 Corinthians 5:1-21](#)). He modeled it by his own life. He always intended to serve with truth and honesty ([2:17](#); [4:2](#)). As Paul shared the message of Christ, the self-sacrifice of Christ's cross was his pattern of service to others ([11:16-33](#)).

Some people questioned Paul's authority. So he shared how God called him to be an apostle and established his ministry in Corinth ([2 Corinthians 10:12-18](#)). Some wanted proof that Christ choose him and criticized Paul's weaknesses ([13:3](#)). So, he pointed to the cross of Jesus and the lessons he learned from it (see [13:4](#); [4:10](#)). Paul knew his own limitations and that he needed God's grace to do his work. An apostle's true authority shows itself in human weakness supported by God's strength ([12:1-10](#)).

Paul performed miraculous works to support his claim to apostleship ([Hebrews 12:12](#)). Yet, these works did not stop doubts among the young church at Corinth. Paul showed great patience in his ministry and did not give up when the Corinthians challenged him. This patience mirrors that of Jesus, who encountered much opposition from others ([Hebrews 12:2-3](#)).

Paul's example offers lessons for everyone involved in Christian service:

1. Christian leaders should regard criticism as an opportunity to evaluate themselves and check if any accusation is true.
2. Christian leaders should remain patient when encountering undeserved opposition and stay focused on their work.
3. It is important to provide a logical defense and explain one's motives, while also acknowledging that the Lord is the ultimate judge.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 10:5–42](#); [28:18–20](#); [Mark 1:17](#); [2:14](#); [3:14–15](#); [John 21:15–17](#); [Acts 1:2–8](#), [20–26](#); [2:42–43](#); [4:33](#); [5:12](#); [6:2–4](#); [10:39–43](#); [14:3](#); [Romans 1:5](#); [15:17–21](#); [1 Corinthians 4:8–13](#); [12:28–29](#); [2 Corinthians 2:17](#); [4:2](#); [6:3–12](#); [10:12–18](#); [Ephesians 2:20](#); [3:4–5](#); [4:11–13](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:7–12](#)

Persecution

Persecution refers to systematic mistreatment, harassment, or oppression of an individual or group because of their identity, beliefs, or practices. In religious contexts specifically, persecution involves the targeting of people for their religious faith or practices.

Persecution is a common experience for God's people. God's servants have often faced hostility and opposition (for example, [Deuteronomy 30:7](#); [1 Kings 18:13](#); [Nehemiah 4:1–3](#); [Jeremiah 37:11–38:28](#); [Matthew 23:34–37](#); [Luke 11:49–51](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:14–16](#)). Jesus himself faced persecution ([Luke 4:28–30](#); [John 5:16](#)).

At the end of his earthly life, he suffered mocking, beating, and a terrible death by crucifixion. He told his disciples to expect similar treatment ([Matthew 10:16–25](#); [24:9](#); [Mark 13:9–13](#); [Luke 21:12–17](#); [John 16:2](#)). He prepared his followers for these times, telling them that the Holy Spirit would give them the courage they needed ([Luke 12:11–12](#); [21:14–15](#); [Acts 1:8](#)).

The book of Acts describes how the earliest Christians faced persecution. It started with the Jewish high council's (Sanhedrin) hostility. Saul of

Tarsus persecuted the early church before he met Jesus in a vision near Damascus ([Acts 8:1–3](#); [9:1–13](#), [21](#); [22:4](#); [26:9–11](#); see [1 Corinthians 15:9](#); [Galatians 1:13](#); [Philippians 3:6](#)). The apostles Peter, John, Stephen, James, Paul, and Barnabas all suffered persecution ([Acts 4:15–18](#); [5:17–18](#); [7:54–60](#); [12:1–4](#); [14:5–6](#)).

In his parable of the farmer and the seed, Jesus explained how persecution affects those with weak faith ([Matthew 13:20–21](#); [Mark 4:16–17](#)). Persecution purifies God's people and helps them become more like Jesus. The apostles' experiences in the book of Acts support Paul's statement: "Indeed, all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus will be persecuted" ([2 Timothy 3:12](#); see [Mark 10:29–30](#)).

Jesus told his disciples to be ready to defend their faith in difficult situations ([Matthew 10:18–20](#); [Luke 21:12–15](#)). The apostles and other leaders did this with courage and boldness (for example, [Acts 4:8–12](#), [31](#); [5:29–32](#); [6:8–10](#); [8:4–40](#); [9:27](#)). The Scriptures encourage Christians to defend their faith bravely and kindly. They must be able to explain their beliefs to those who ask questions ([Colossians 4:6](#); [2 Timothy 2:24–25](#); [1 Peter 3:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 18:2–15](#); [19:1–18](#); [Nehemiah 4:1–3](#); [Jeremiah 37:1–38:28](#); [Matthew 10:16–39](#); [13:20–21](#); [23:34–38](#); [24:9–14](#); [Mark 10:29–31](#); [13:9–13](#); [Luke 11:47–51](#);

sing when God's salvation arrived (see [Isaiah 55:12](#)).

When Jesus entered Jerusalem at the end of his ministry, his disciples shouted. They "began to praise God joyfully in a loud voice for all the miracles they had seen" ([Luke 19:37](#)). The Pharisees asked Jesus to silence his disciples. But he replied, "if they remain silent, the very stones will cry out" ([19:37-40](#)).

At the end of the book, the disciples "returned to Jerusalem with great joy, praising God continually in the temple" ([24:52-53](#)). The arrival of God's marvelous salvation is a reason for joy and praise.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 55:12](#); [Luke 1:44-47](#), [64](#), [68](#); [2:13-14](#), [38](#); [5:25-26](#); [7:16](#); [13:13](#); [17:15-18](#); [18:43](#); [19:37-40](#); [24:51-53](#); [Acts 2:47](#); [3:8-9](#); [4:21](#); [11:18](#); [13:48](#); [21:20](#)

Praise Psalms

The Hebrew title of the book of Psalms means "Praises." This idea fits many of the psalms. The psalms praise God for his nature and great acts in creation and history. People wrote praise psalms for both personal and community use.

Individual praise ([Psalms 9](#); [18](#); [32](#); [34](#); [116](#); [138](#)): In temple worship, people often gave thanks aloud in front of everyone when they made a vow or thank offering (see, for example, [22:22-26](#); [66:13-20](#); [116:17-19](#)). These moments of personal praise and testimony added warmth and meaning to worship. Each rescue and experience of God's mercy became part of the continuing story of salvation. Worship was more than just remembering God's acts from the past.

Communal praise ([Psalms 103](#), [113](#), [124](#), [129](#), [136](#)): When the community gathered, they sang to praise the Lord for his historical acts ([Psalm 103](#)). Or they would praise him for a recent display of his mercy ([Psalms 124](#), [129](#)).

In [Psalm 103](#), the psalmist praises God for his mercy to individuals and the entire community (verses [1-5](#), [6-14](#)). Human weakness contrasts with God's reliability (verses [15-18](#)). His universal and absolute rule deserves praise from everyone and everything (verses [19-22](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 9](#); [18](#); [32](#); [34](#); [46-48](#); [93](#); [96-99](#); [103](#); [113](#); [116](#); [124](#); [129](#); [136](#); [138](#)

Prayers for Vengeance

Vengeance is punishment inflicted in return for a wrong suffered. It is the act of causing harm to someone as a response to harm they have caused. The writers of the psalms (called psalmists) sometimes asked God to punish their enemies. It was common for them to pray for the violent destruction of their enemies as a sign of God's justice. How can this type of prayer be acceptable?

These prayers for the destruction of the evil people come from a desire for justice and trust in God. [Psalm 1:6](#) explains divine justice. God protects the righteous and destroys evil people. The evil people are corrupt and committed to what is wrong. They oppose God and everything God does. They oppose morals, society, and God's kingdom.

The psalmists argued that evil does not align with God's nature. Removing evil is necessary for his kingdom to thrive. Yet, the poets of Israel did not call for God's judgment on anyone they disliked. Instead, the psalmists followed God's standards of justice and righteousness, which God expects all humans to follow.

The psalmists knew grief well. They suffered and experienced oppression from bullies, leaders, and kings both within and outside Israel. Their prayers were full of faith and hope. They questioned how long God would allow their suffering. They affirmed that only the Lord could save them from evil.

They deeply longed for his redemption. They asked God to make the wicked suffer as they had, following the principle of revenge ([Psalm 5:10](#); [6:10](#); [7:9](#); [9:19-20](#); [28:4](#); [56:7](#); [104:35](#);

God shows us how we should pray for those who oppose us. Jesus will indeed judge and bring a final end to evil (see [Revelation 19:11–21](#)). But while Christians wait for that final judgment, they are to love as Jesus loved ([John 13:34](#)). They should pray for their enemies and forgive them ([Matthew 5:38–48](#); [Colossians 3:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Chronicles 24:22](#); [Nehemiah 4:5](#); [Psalms 3:7](#); [9:19–20](#); [10:15](#); [12:3](#); [41:10](#); [55:15](#); [69:22–28](#); [79:6](#); [109:6–20](#); [110:5–6](#); [137:1–9](#); [Isaiah 61:2](#); [Jeremiah 11:20–23](#); [18:19–23](#); [51:35](#); [Lamentations 1:22](#); [3:64–66](#); [Acts 1:20](#); [Romans 11:9–10](#); [Revelation 6:10](#)

Preaching to a Tough Crowd

Sometimes God asks people to share the good news about Jesus with a difficult audience. The listeners might resist God's truth and reject both the message and the messenger. This was especially true for the Old Testament prophets, who often shared messages that people did not want to hear (see [Jeremiah 26:7–9](#); [38:1–6](#); [Amos 7:10–13](#)).

The prophet Malachi preached to a difficult audience. His congregation included people who were:

- disappointed ([Malachi 1:2](#))
- distrusting ([1:7](#); [2:2](#))
- uncaring ([2:13–16](#))
- dishonest ([3:5](#))
- disinterested ([3:14–15](#))
- doubting, skeptical, and the truly wicked (see [4:1](#))

What should a preacher say to such a group?

Malachi used conversation to engage his audience in a series of debates. The prophet gave a strong correction that cleverly answered the objections people might raise before they could speak. His message was powerful and made people pay attention: “those who feared the LORD spoke with one another, and the LORD listened and heard them” ([Malachi 3:16](#)).

Like the prophets, both Jesus and his followers shared messages with audiences who resisted them (see, for example, [Luke 4:16–30](#); [John 10:22–](#)

[40](#); [Acts 5:26–40](#); [22:30–23:10](#)). Yet, this resistance did not stop them from fulfilling their God-given duty to share the good news about Jesus (see [Acts 5:41–42](#)). Those who preach the Lord's message can hope for a positive response like Malachi did. But, that is not always guaranteed.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 19:6–11](#); [Exodus 17:1–13](#); [Judges 9:1–21](#); [1 Kings 22:8–28](#); [Jeremiah 28:1–17](#); [Malachi 3:14–18](#); [John 10:24–39](#); [Acts 22:30–23:10](#)

Pride and Humility

Pride is a feeling people naturally have when they succeed or achieve something. Many people in the world value being recognized and famous (see [1 John 2:16](#)). However, pride comes from thinking too much about yourself, and often leads to making others seem less important. The Bible often warns against pride and the harm it can cause. Instead, the Bible encourages people to be humble.

The book of Proverbs connects humility with wisdom (see [Proverbs 11:2](#)). Wisdom begins with revering or fearing the Lord ([1:7](#)). Wisdom recognizes God's power and importance. A humble person admits mistakes and accepts correction from others ([10:17](#); [12:1](#)). But pride can prevent learning from others. It can cause conflict ([13:10](#)). It leads to disgrace ([11:2](#)).

In the divine plan, pride leads to downfall and shame, while humility brings honor ([Proverbs 11:2](#); [18:12](#); [29:23](#)). People asked Jesus, “Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” He indicated that the model was the pure humility of a child ([Matthew 18:1–5](#)).

In another story, Jesus shared a parable comparing the proud prayer of a religious leader with the humble prayer of a tax collector. He concluded with the words, “For everyone who ex

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 3:5-14](#); [2 Chronicles 26:14-20](#); [Proverbs 10:17](#); [11:2](#); [12:15](#); [15:5](#); [22:4](#); [29:23](#); [Matthew 5:5](#); [18:4](#); [21:5](#); [Luke 18:9-14](#); [Ephesians 4:2](#); [Philippians 2:3](#); [James 1:21](#); [3:13](#); [4:10](#)

Promised Land

God gave the first man and woman the task of governing the earth and ruling over creation. This was to meet their needs and honor the creator ([Genesis 1:28-30](#)). But when humanity sinned, they became separated from God, each other, and the land on which they lived ([3:17-19](#); see [4:3-16](#); compare [5:29](#)).

God called Abram to follow him by faith and receive Canaan as a special homeland. This land was a promised place for his descendants as God's people ([Genesis 12:1-3](#), [7](#); [13:14-18](#); [15:7-21](#); [17:7-8](#)). Later, God freed Israel from slavery in Egypt. At Mount Sinai, he made a covenant (special agreement) with them to be his people. Then they received the land promised to their ancestors.

Keeping the land depended on obedience. If Israel violated the covenant, they would encounter its curses. The worst curse was exile from the promised land ([Leviticus 26:32-33](#)). This eventually happened because of Israel's continued rebellion against the Lord. He sent them into exile to Assyria and Babylon. They lost their land, and their enemies destroyed the temple of God ([2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [25:1-21](#)).

Yet, God also promises that when the people repent, "then I will remember My covenant ... and I will remember the land" ([Leviticus 26:42](#)). During the exile to Babylon, the prophet Jeremiah and other prophets saw God's future restoration of his people and their return to the land ([Jeremiah 32:36-44](#)). This happened during the rule of King Cyrus the Great of Persia (see the books of Ezra and Nehemiah).

The promises about the land still wait for their final fulfillment. God plans to prepare an eternal homeland for his people. In this homeland, God will rule directly and justly as king. Everyone and everything will follow God's will. Death and sin will no longer exist. The needs of God's people will be fully met ([Hebrews 11:13-16](#); [Revelation 21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:28-30](#); [3:15-19](#); [4:3-16](#); [12:1-3](#), [7](#); [13:14-18](#); [15:1-21](#); [17:7-8](#); [Exodus 6:1-13](#); [Leviticus 26:1-46](#); [1 Kings 8:22-53](#); [9:1-9](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [25:1-21](#); [Jeremiah 32:36-44](#); [Hebrews 11:13-16](#); [Revelation 21:1-27](#)

Prophetic Sign Acts

The prophets of Israel sometimes used sign acts to share their messages. Sign acts were dramatic actions performed in public to make their message stronger. These visual demonstrations helped people not only *hear* the truth but also *feel* it deeply. The purpose of these actions was to create a message that people would not forget.

These acts were unusual and strange—not just to people today but also to people in ancient times. However, unlike people today (who might think the prophet had mental problems), people in ancient times understood that these sign acts were a normal way prophets communicated their messages.

The prophet Ezekiel often acted out his messages more than any other prophet. This was probably because he spoke to a very stubborn audience ([Ezekiel 2:6-7](#)). These actions emphasized his message and showed his deep commitment. For instance, he ate God's word ([Ezekiel 2:8-3:3](#)). Then Ezekiel demonstrated it to the exiles through a series of judgment scenes ([Ezekiel 3:4-9](#); see also chapters [4-6](#)). This dramatic communication is hard for even an angry audience to ignore or forget.

Jesus Christ performed the ultimate sign act on the cross (see [Matthew 27:32-54](#)). There, God showed his judgment against sin with darkness, an earthquake, and the suffering of his sinless Son who seemed abandoned by his Father. God also showed his deep love for the world by choosing to die rather than lose his people. The cross is a powerful message of God's love and judgment that is hard to ignore or forget.

Passages for Further Study

[Jeremiah 13:1-11](#); [19:1-15](#); [25:15](#)

Prophets in 1 Kings

A prophet is a person chosen by God to speak on God's behalf to people. Prophets receive special messages directly from God and then share these messages with others. God's prophets were important in the Old Testament kingdoms of Israel and Judah. They helped with daily needs, challenged kings and priests about their unfaithfulness, and performed many miracles. They shared God's future plans, especially messages of judgment ([1 Kings 11:29-32](#); [17:1-13:1-2](#); [20:42](#); [21:20-23](#); [22:20-22](#)).

Several examples from 1 Kings show the role of prophets:

- The faithful prophet Nathan corrected King David about his sin with Bathsheba ([2 Samuel 12:1-12](#)). Nathan played a key role in stopping Adonijah from stealing David's rule ([1 Kings 1:5-49](#)).
- The prophet Ahijah told Jeroboam that God planned to divide Solomon's kingdom after his death ([1 Kings 11:29-39](#)). Later, God used an unnamed prophet to condemn Jeroboam's false religion and the altar at Bethel ([13:1-10](#)). He also showed the results of disobeying the Lord's command ([13:11-32](#)). Ahijah returned to announce the Lord's judgment against Jeroboam and his descendants ([14:1-16](#)).
- The prophet Jehu announced judgment on King Baasha because he continued to sin like Jeroboam ([1 Kings 16:1-4](#)).
- Much of 1 Kings focuses on the prophet Elijah ([17:1-19:21](#); [21:17-28](#)). He was God's main spokesman during King Ahab's rule (though other prophets were also active; see [20:38-43](#); [22:17-28](#)).

In 1 Kings, the prophets received different reactions from the kings of Israel and Judah. The story shows the importance of listening to God's prophets and the risks of ignoring them. Through the prophets, God tried to stop the disasters that would come from the people's disobedience. Sadly,

many kings did not listen to the prophets, leading to the prophesied destruction.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 11:29-39](#); [13:1-32](#); [14:1-16](#); [16:2-4](#); [17:1-18:46](#); [19:1-21](#); [20:35-43](#); [21:17-28](#); [22:10-28](#); [2 Kings 17:13-15](#)

Psalms of Suffering

The four psalms of suffering (Psalms 16, 22, 40, and 69) describe the intense distress experienced by God's servant. They are also called "Passion Psalms."

[Psalm 22](#) uses some of the most powerful language about suffering in the psalms. In this psalm, God's servant suffers even though he is righteous. There is no mention of any sin, so the psalmist's suffering seems completely unfair. Despite being treated very badly, there is no prayer for revenge (see [Psalm 137](#)).

This psalm has important connections to Jesus' death on the cross (for example, [Psalm 22:6-8](#), [14-18](#)). In fact, Jesus quoted part of [Psalm 22](#) while hanging on the cross ([22:1](#); see [Matthew 27:46](#)). The sinless Christ even prayed for those who killed him ([Luke 23:34](#)).

Other psalms of suffering also became linked with Jesus. [Psalm 16:10](#) anticipates Jesus' victory over death (see [Acts 2:24-31](#)). [Psalm 40:6-8](#) suggests Jesus' selfless, redemptive work ([Hebrews 10:5-10](#)). [Psalm 69](#) speaks of isolation because of commitment to God's cause ([69:8-9](#)). It also predicts the disciple Judas' role in God's work through Christ ([69:25-26](#); see [Psalm 109:8](#); [Isaiah 53:10](#); [Acts 1:20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 16](#); [22](#); [40](#); [69](#); [102](#); [109](#); [Isaiah 42:1-9](#); [52:13-53:12](#); [Matthew 27:46](#); [Luke 23:34](#); [Hebrews 10:5-10](#)

Pure Worship

From the start of God's relationship with Israel, he provided ways for their worship of him to be pleasing to him ([Exodus 20-40](#); [Leviticus 1](#)

When King Solomon built the temple as a permanent place for worship, he carefully created "a house for the Name of the LORD my God" ([1 Kings 5:3-5](#)). He followed the given design, correctly placed the ark of the covenant in the inner holy place, and offered the temple to the Lord ([8:1-11](#); see [Deuteronomy 16:13-17](#)). Solomon obeyed the law's rules (see, for example, [Exodus 25:10-22](#)). These rules intended to keep Israel's worship focused on the Lord and his commands.

People often worship based on their own desires instead of following God's instructions. Israel was no exception. In his later years, Solomon was unfaithful to the Lord by worshiping other gods ([1 Kings 11:4-8](#)). After Solomon died, Jeroboam created a rival, idol-worshipping religion in the northern kingdom. He plainly violated God's law ([14:9-10, 15-16](#)).

False worship was common in the northern kingdom throughout its history (for example, [1 Kings 15:26; 16:13, 25-26, 30-33; 21:25-26](#)). Meanwhile, in the southern kingdom of Judah, local pagan altars were a constant spiritual distraction ([15:14; 22:43](#)). Neither Judah nor Israel were faithful in their worship of the Lord.

There is one God, and his people must worship only him ([1 Kings 8:23](#); see [Deuteronomy 5:7, 9; 6:4; John 14:6; Acts 4:12](#)). Our worship must come from a pure heart. We must stay completely faithful to the Lord in committed service to him ([1 Kings 15:14; 17:1](#); see [Deuteronomy 10:12, 20; Psalm 24:3-4; Matthew 4:10; John 4:24](#)). In our daily and weekly worship of God we should feel his presence, bringing genuine joy ([1 Kings 8:56](#); compare [Psalm 63:1-3; Philippians 4:4](#)).

Israel's temple was a holy place meant to attract all people to worship ([1 Kings 8:41-43](#)). So, Christians, who are the temple of the living God, should live in a way that attracts and motivates others to know the Lord and worship him ([1 Corinthians 3:16-17; Matthew 5:16; Acts 2:40-47; 2 Timothy 4:5; 1 Peter 2:12](#)). Our whole lives should include daily worship of Christ, recognizing him as Lord ([1 Peter 3:15](#)). We must not let any idol take God's place in our lives ([1 John 5:21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 8:20; Exodus 4:31; 25:10-22; Leviticus 1:1-8:36; Deuteronomy 5:7-9; 6:4-9; 10:12, 20; 16:13-17; 26:1-15; 1 Kings 5:3-5; Psalms 24:3-6; 51:1-19; Hosea 6:6; 14:1-2; Micah 6:6-8; Matthew 4:10; 5:16; 6:1-18; John 4:19-24; 5:23; 14:6; Acts 2:40-47; Romans 12:1-2; 1 Corinthians 3:16-17;](#)

[14:1-40; Philippians 3:3; Hebrews 10:1-25; 1 Peter 3:15; 1 John 5:21; Revelation 5:9-13; 15:3](#)

Purim

The Feast of Purim is the only Old Testament feast not established during the time of Moses. Its name comes from a word meaning *lots* or *dice* (Hebrew *purim*, from Akkadian *puru*). In ancient times, people often cast *purim* to see if God approved of an action. A good number meant approval, while a bad number meant disapproval.

Near the king's throne room at Susa in Persia, archaeologists found a small four-sided object with numbers on each side. A similar die with the word *pur* dates back to the 800s BC. In the book of Esther, Persian astrologers used *purim* to decide the best time to attack the Jews ([Esther 3:7](#)).

On March 7, 473 BC, God saved his people from certain death, similar to the rescue from Egypt during Passover. Mordecai and Esther established an annual celebration to remember God's rescue for future generations ([Esther 9:28](#)). Later in history, Jews widely celebrated the feast (see 2 Maccabees 15:36; Josephus, *Antiquities* 11.6.13; possibly [John 5:1](#)).

When God saved his chosen people, the day intended for the destruction of the Jews became a day of their victory over their enemies. It was followed by celebration. Today, Jewish people fast and pray to remember how Queen Esther fasted before she bravely approached the king. This fast comes right before Purim, which happens on the fourteenth day of the month of Adar (in February or March).

During the joyful holiday of Purim, Jews read the story of Esther, loudly booing Haman and cheering for Mordecai. They enjoy special meals

Purity and Identity

God is holy, and he made a covenant (special agreement) with Israel to establish a holy nation ([Exodus 19:4-6](#); [Leviticus 19:2](#)). Being God's people meant Israel needed to be pure in worship and social relationships. God knew that if his people became part of the culture of their pagan neighbors, they would adopt evil worship practices (see [Numbers 25:1-9](#)). Their failure to stay pure and their blending with these cultures eventually led to their destruction and exile ([2 Kings 17:5-23](#)).

When the priest and scribe Ezra wrote to the Jews who had returned to Jerusalem, he intended to remind them to remain pure to their beliefs and commitments. After arriving in Jerusalem, Ezra discovered that the people had married pagan foreigners, which was against God's law (see [Deuteronomy 7:3-4](#); [Joshua 23:12-13](#)). This threatened their identity as God's holy nation ([Ezra 9:1-2](#)).

The book of Ezra emphasizes the need to separate from foreigners. It recounts how those who first returned to Jerusalem refused to cooperate with the pagan people around them ([Ezra 4:1-5](#)). These people claimed to worship the same God but actually worshiped several gods in addition to the Lord. If the Jews had joined them, they would have compromised their beliefs and become ungodly, as Israel had before the exile to Babylon (see [Exodus 34:15-16](#); [1 Kings 11:1-5](#); [2 Kings 16:3](#)).

The early Jewish leaders in Judea understood the danger of tolerating these foreigners. They learned from their ancestors' experiences and refused to compromise the purity of their faith for the sake of so-called peace. They carefully followed God's instructions in everything they did ([Ezra 3:2, 9; 6:18](#)). To identify as "servants of the God of heaven and earth," they needed to please and serve him alone ([5:11](#)).

Today, Christians are God's holy people ([1 Peter 2:9](#)). This is a title that indicates purity. The apostle Paul advised the Corinthians not to marry non-Christians, as Christ and Satan have nothing "in common" ([2 Corinthians 6:14-15](#)). Righteousness and unrighteousness do not mix. God's people must avoid behavior that corrupts. Instead, they must adopt attitudes and actions that match their holy status ([Colossians 3:5-15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 27:46-28:5](#); [Exodus 19:4-6](#); [34:15-16](#); [Leviticus 19:2](#); [Deuteronomy 7:3-4](#); [Joshua 23:12-](#)

[13](#); [1 Kings 11:1-5](#); [Ezra 4:1-5](#); [5:11](#); [9:1-10:11](#); [Malachi 2:15](#); [1 Corinthians 6:15-20](#); [2 Corinthians 6:14-18](#); [2 Timothy 2:21-22](#); [1 Peter 2:9-10](#)